Gute Nacht

After 169 days in investigative custody, Honecker's trial – dogged by blunders and a tangle of paperwork – finally ended on 12 January 1993. The last throw of the dice by petitioning Berlin's Constitutional Court worked. Judges ruled his further imprisonment was inconsistent with respect for human dignity leading to the Berlin District Court abandoning the case.1 All this was 'extremely stressful for Honecker,' says Becker, as prosecutors tried until the last second to prevent his release and departure:

A famous medical professor who had agreed to examine Honecker as a private doctor informed the Prosecutors on the night before Honecker's departure by breaking his duty of medical confidentiality, saying that he could 'repair' Honecker to make him fit to stand the trial. We sued him later and this break confidentiality cost him 10,000 Euros. But the prosecutors did not succeed because a reversal of the decisions to release Honecker was legally and politically impossible also, considering the media frenzy where journalists booked every airplane to South America and left in the last minute because Honecker took another plane. The whole affair had taken speed, had accelerated towards his release and his travel to Chile, that it just could not be stopped.

Interestingly, the lead prosecutor told Becker that he would have asked for the maximum punishment of fifteen years for Honecker if the trial had continued.